

What's the Buzz about?

Bringing music into your life over the Net, that too legally—that's what Sudhanshu Sarronwala does. We focus the spotlight on the man and his latest venture, Soundbuzz.com

VIDYARAMANAN S.

A successful businessman is one who realises an opportunity, seizes the moment and makes good use of it. Sudhanshu Sarronwala fits this description right down to the last detail. With a mathematical base from Delhi University and a business degree from IIM Lucknow, Sarronwala is at the helm of affairs at Singapore-based Soundbuzz.com as its CEO. Soundbuzz.com is the first of its kind to offer digitally encrypted music in Asia. Till date, Soundbuzz.com has been the key player in digital distribution of music in the Asian region.

Music is nothing new to Sarronwala, who has an extensive broadcast and media background



Sudhanshu Sarronwala, CEO,
Soundbuzz.com

“I want to make the artist, the recording companies and the online distributor happy on their way to the bank”

with over 10 years of experience managing media businesses in Asia. He enjoys the distinction of being the former managing director of MTV Asia and the senior vice president of MTV Networks Asia. While at MTV, he realised the potential of music in the Asian and Asia-Pacific region. The vision became a reality in the form of Soundbuzz.com.

In early 1999, Napster brought along with it all the questions related to copyright infringement. Sarronwala liked the way Napster was using technology to distribute music, but he preferred doing it the right way—the legal way. He was aware that a simple dotcom model would not generate revenue, and figured out strategic

plans to act as a music aggregator rather than just a digital music distributor. He wanted to bring in a close interaction between the artiste, record labels and the distributor. “I want to make all three happy on their way to the bank,” quips Sarronwala.

The inspiration from Napster, coupled with the aspiration to make all the players content, and at the same time a vision to distribute music digitally in a secure manner paved the road for Soundbuzz.com.

While other digital distributors of music viewed the aspect from the technology standpoint, Sarronwala looked at it from a music industry perspective. According to Sarronwala, “Digital music is the biggest thing since the invention of CDs. It's the biggest threat and also the biggest opportunity for the music industry.”

The music industry has a projected growth from \$10 to 50 million a year, and is expected to grow to a massive \$150 million industry in three years according to IDC estimates. Sarronwala believes that he could reap the rewards by helping record labels do decent and legal business over the Web.

Today, this speaks volumes for the success of Soundbuzz.com in the Asian region. In India, the company has joined hands with a repertoire of Indian music labels to distribute old and new music labels via the Internet. Using the latest Digital Rights Management technology from Microsoft and distributing the music in the Windows Media 8 format enables the company to distribute music in a highly secure fashion, at the same time helping the music industry protect copyrights. The channels of distribution are going to be many-fold, ranging from computer manufacturers, wireless devices, Internet, MP3 players and many more to come in the near future.

He also has plans to introduce patented pieces of music for cell phone users. Today there are plenty of Web sites that offer downloadable ringer tones for cell phones. Soundbuzz is also working on similar grounds for releasing patented ringer tones.

Will Soundbuzz.com be a successful player in a field full of free and illegal services such as Napster and Audiogalaxy? Time is the best answer to that question. ■